weight should be given to political values. It is surely not without reason that seven decades later, this debate is still very much in vogue.

MASANI'S PERSPECTIVE

There are many examples of what we may consider to be current issues actually being debated in our history. Those I have cited above give some flavour of what our past holds, if only political correctness does not stand in the way of objective exploration. Among the long-held tenets of Indian foreign policy is that of non-alignment. Even though it has a particular global context, this has sought to be made into an immutable concept. That India's capabilities now allow it to move beyond defensive options is often lost on those who treat policy debates as theological ones. But precisely because it is invoked so often, a critical viewpoint is also worth recognizing.

Few questioned the predicaments that the practice of non-alignment could create for India more graphically than M.R. Masani in 1959. And he did so, understandably, as the threat from China loomed large. Masani essentially asked whether our approach had brought us to a point where we were unable to repel effectively an attack on our own territory. Related to that, he suggested that by keeping a distance from the West, we were not even able to equip our forces adequately. But more fundamentally, he was concerned that India's capacity to recognize a dangerous neighbour had somehow got impaired. Its domestic reflection was discouraging our own people from even displaying patriotism. In effect, Masani was bringing out that non-alignment, while working in good times, was less productive in tough ones. Keeping a distance from others also meant that they too kept their own when they wished. Masani believed that non-alignment was not inconsistent with the capacity to recognize a dangerous neighbour and take measures accordingly. Significantly, much of what he said tallied with Nehru's hesitation to engage Western powers even as China advanced into India in November 1962.

As with the other examples, this debate, too, is worth revisiting because of endeavours to put India under pressure. When others extol our independence and strategic autonomy, it is not always meant for India's good. They seek instead to influence our thinking in a manner that constrains our options. In that quest, it is natural that they would use our